

tempo talk

I've really had an earful . . .



MARILYN: Left lobe, but not always.

THERE isn't really any escape. Not when such an awesome trio as Queen Elizabeth II, Elton John and Marilyn all wear earrings.

Earrings are supposed to tell you a lot about males. Legend has it that you can tell their leanings by which ear they use. The trouble is I can never remember which ear is which.

Elton John goes for wonderful circles, diamond studded, and he tends to wear them in his right ear. Marilyn has gold rings, which dangle like chandeliers, little gold figures and such. He likes to wear them on his left lobe. But not always. Occasionally he has them on both ears. What does that mean?

Frankly I have never gone for earrings. My lobes are my poorest feature, terribly undistinguished. But, dear

By KEITH DUNSTAN

reader, we are very strong on females in our family and these past six months have been painful.

One daughter wears contact lenses. You must appreciate that the combination of contact lenses and earrings is deadly. She lost one pair of pearl earrings down the lavatory bowl. Sadly she had been using one of these "miracle" detergents and it was a miracle indeed. It dissolved the pearls fast as you bat your eyelid.

Then she dropped a sapphire earring down the plug hole of the wash basin. Your clever handyman was able to say: "No problem. Your earring will be lodged in the plumbing down below."

So it was, but it was one of these charming houses made in the days of Queen Victoria. The old lead pipe came adrift completely. One was able to say: "The cost of restoring the wash basin was infinitely more than your earring."

My wife came to earrings only a few months ago. It was daughter-inspired and the ultimate decision was made suddenly one morning. We went to three chemists before we found one who could do it, while you wait, so to speak.

ZAP! He fired his gun, faster than you can bat an eyelid.

□

Yet there was a strong shock which affected the psyche, almost like getting married. She had holes in her ears. She wasn't perfect any more.

The agony was just starting. There was the month to six weeks of wearing those darned sleepers in the ears, which were never quite comfortable. Then there was the problem of the holes closing up. Unless the earrings were worn all night the holes tended to disappear for ever.

Well, to let you into a real secret, in moments of devotion I am an ear lobe nibbler. Have you ever gone for an ear lobe and ended up with a mouth full of metal or precious rock?

I tell you, the finer problems of living with earrings would fill a book. For a start they have little gold things on the back called "keepers". When removed they roll rather well. We're putting in a few man hours looking for keepers under wardrobes, under beds.

Then you reach the stage, which comes to all of us — Telecom provides absurdly small print in telephone books. So you can't find the absurdly small holes in ear lobes. Screams of pain when one jabs in the wrong spot.



ELTON JOHN: Earring on the right.

The crisis comes when we are already a quarter of an hour late going out for dinner. You know how it is. First you have to find the earrings, then there's the search for the bifocals to see the ear lobes, to find the tiny holes, to get the pin through without dropping the little gold keeper.

Oh yes, there's more to earrings than meets the eye. However what meets the eye is becoming more and more astonishing. On a quick tour around town we counted 187 different bizarre styles of earrings. It seems that only the males like Elton are wearing diamonds at the moment. You have to go in for curious objects.

We have seen gnomes with rolling eyes, fans that open, large mice, table tennis bat and ball, lips and lips, would you believe, with a cigarette hanging on them.

We have seen strawberries, scissors, scorpions, fish, lemons, hands, a cup and saucer and coat hangers. Coat hangers make very nice earrings. After all, a girl never has enough coat hangers.

You can have music notes, cats, fans, pencils, bunches of grapes, dice, frogs, roller-skates, razor blades and quite delightful little zip fasteners which really zip.

There are forks, daggers, note pad and pencil, an abacus almost two inches long with moving beads, bottle openers, egg in a frying pan, cigarette butts, garden taps or a pair of feet.

For \$1.50 you can purchase telephone earrings, which is very nice. It would be difficult to find anything that would symbolise a young woman better than a telephone.

Then there's a gentleman who is producing spider earrings. He is very clever at bronzing real huntsman spiders which are large and awesomely spectacular. It's a daunting prospect. Imagine swallowing a spider in the middle of the night.

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The street with no name

THERE were no blondes in sight when I emerged from Customs recently at Narita Airport in Japan.

Half an hour passed and still no sign of a certain party.

After an hour I started to whimper to myself: What am I going to do? I don't even know her address. She doesn't know her address — only how to get there. She says that even if she could find her street name it'd be written in Japanese...

Just then my daughter breezed up, sprouting hugs and kisses. "Hi, Mum! Sorry I'm late. I was bailed up by the police for not carrying my passport."

I'd flown to Japan from Hong Kong after being Cathay Pacific's guest on their inaugural Sydney/Frankfurt flight. "Why don't you break the trip on the way back and go and see your daughter?" the editor of this paper had said. "I know how much you're missing her."

The last words from a brave friend before I left Sydney had been: "Now don't you act the mother. Remember you're her guest and shut your mouth."

So when the 19-year-old and I arrived at her tiny flat in the street with no name in a part of Tokyo called Hiro-o, I made no comment about the dead carnations or the breakfast dishes or the line of washing strung across the tiny sitting room-cum-kitchen.

"I keep it that way to remind me of home," she chuckled, gesturing towards her bedroom which was carpeted with clothes. "Oh, you are a trick!" I laughed through clenched crowns.

Next morning after she'd gone to work (she's been fashion modelling in Japan since January), I stepped gingerly into the bedroom to check whether there was anything of hers I could wear (now there's a switch).

"Mum's been a regular little homebody," she told a clutch of models at a restaurant that evening, eyes rolling significantly. "She even made my bed. I never make my bed except to change the sheets."

"Wastes time, Jood," a male American model looking like Gregory Peck the Younger told me.

"What's it like — staying with your daughter?" one of the girls asked.

My daughter answered for me: "It's funny — sort of an about-face — me being responsible for Mum."

After this I didn't put a foot out of line. There was

up
tempo
with
Judy Johnson



only one slip-up — when she asked me if I thought she'd changed.

"Well, you've got this funny little giggle now," I said. "You put your hand over your mouth and look up through your eyelashes."

Her gaze froze. "You've got to act feminine here," she said coldly. "If you act as if you know it all in front of Japanese men, you don't get the work."

I must say I feel sorry for Japanese women. We went out for dinner most nights and in each restaurant there'd be tableful of business-suited men. Not a wife-type in sight. One Friday we caught the train home about 11.30pm and the subway station was sardined with them and the air heavy with sake. We got into the train and they rushed the seats. No-one stands up for women, not even schoolkids.

An American who's been working in Tokyo for five years says it's done for Japanese men to be married by the time they're 26 and after the first child is born, most of them lose interest in their wives. Then it's done for the husband to acquire a girlfriend or two.

This fits in with their reputation as the ultimate consumers. A model told me: "When a new stereo or toaster hits the market they throw out their old one, even though it works perfectly. That's how most of us have furnished our apartments — from the trash cans."

All the models are skilled at using Tokyo's efficient subway system and after a few days so was I.

There was really no alternative. The traffic is dense and you can hardly get into a taxi with a driver who can't speak English and ask to be taken to a street with no name.